ਬੰਦੀ ਛੋੜ ਦਿਵਸ

Bandi Chhor Divas — a study guide

At a glance · ਇੱਕ ਨਜ਼ਰ

ਸ੍ਰੀ ਗੁਰੂ ਹਰਿਗੋਬਿੰਦ ਸਾਹਿਬ ਜੀ — ਛੇਵੇਂ ਪਾਤਿਸ਼ਾਹ

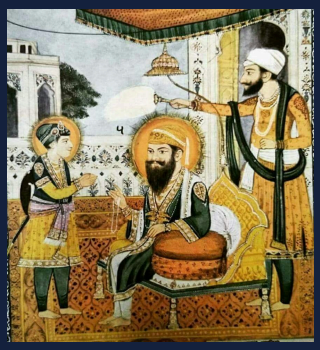
	Bikrami (ਗੁਰਬਾਣੀ ਪਾਠ ਦਰਪਣ)	CE	Place
ਪ੍ਰਕਾਸ਼ · Prakash	੧੬੫੨, ਹਾੜ੍ਹ ਵਦੀ ੧, ਐਤਵਾਰ	—	ਵਡਾਲੀ ਸਾਹਿਬ, six miles from Amritsar
ਗੁਰਗੱਦੀ · Gurgaddi	੧੬੬੩, ਜੇਠ ਵਦੀ ੮	—	ਕੋਠੜੀ ਸਾਹਿਬ, Amritsar
ਸ੍ਰੀ ਅਕਾਲ ਤਖ਼ਤ ਸਾਹਿਬ	੫ ਹਾੜ੍ਹ ੧੬੬੩ (teaching deck)	—	Amritsar
ਗਵਾਲੀਅਰ · Gwalior	sources differ	sources differ	Gwalior Fort
ਜੋਤੀ ਜੋਤਿ · Jyoti Jyot	੧੬੬੫, ਚੇਤ ਸੁਦੀ ੫ (per Darpan)	28 March 1638	ਕੀਰਤਪੁਰ ਸਾਹਿਬ
Age · Guriai	੪੨ ਬਰਸ ੯ ਮਹੀਨੇ ੧੯ ਦਿਨ · ੩੨ ਬਰਸ ੧੦ ਮਹੀਨੇ ੧੨ ਦਿਨ		

Mata Ganga Ji and Sri Guru Arjan Dev Ji were Guru Sahib Ji's parents. **This year Bandi Chhor Divas falls on ੨੩ ਕੱਤਕ ੫੫੮ ਨਾਨਕਸ਼ਾਹੀ, Sunday 8 November 2026.**

Why some boxes are empty. Darpan prints the Prakash as 6 June 1596, while 1652 Bk usually converts to 1595, and Darpan's 15 May 1605 for the Gurgaddi sits before the shaheedi of 1663 Bk, so both CE dates are left out until they are checked. For Gwalior, our sources give anything from forty days to several years, and years from 1611 to 1619, so this guide gives no figure. Darpan's own footnote gives 1701 Bk for the Jyoti Jyot in three other granths.

The story in four sakhis: 1. Why Gwalior · 2. In the fort · 3. The release · 4. Coming home.

ਸਾਖੀ ੧ — ਗਵਾਲੀਅਰ ਕਿਉਂ? · Why Gwalior



Sri Guru Arjan Dev Ji with the young Sri Guru Hargobind Sahib Ji. Late 19th or early 20th century, public domain.

The heat of shaheedi. Chandu, a minister at Jahangir's court, nursed a grudge against the house of Sri Guru Nanak Dev Ji. Through his envy and the emperor's order, Sri Guru Arjan Dev Ji were held in Lahore and tortured. Fire was all around and the body blistered. Sain Mian Mir Ji, a Muslim faqir who loved Guru Sahib Ji, came, saw, wept, and offered to intervene. Guru Sahib Ji asked them to let the Will of Akal Purakh unfold, and said, in the words of a later poet:

> ਕਿਆ ਹੂਆ ਤਨ ਜਲ ਰਹਾ, ਹਮ ਸ਼ਾਂਤ ਹੈ ਹਰੀ ਨਾਮ ਸੇ ।
> What if the body burns? With Hari's Naam we are at peace.

Before going to Lahore, Guru Sahib Ji had Baba Buddha Ji place the tilak of guriai on the young Sri Guru Hargobind Sahib Ji, and asked that the sangat be told openly that Sri Guru Hargobind Sahib Ji now sat on the gurgaddi.

Two swords. On the gurgaddi Sri Guru Hargobind Sahib Ji put on two swords: **ਪੀਰੀ** (the spiritual authority) and **ਮੀਰੀ** (the temporal). Piri is named first, because the right to bear arms grows out of wisdom and bandagi, never the other way round. Sri Guru Gobind Singh Ji later gave the same pair another name: ਦੇਗ਼ and ਤੇਗ਼, the langar pot and the sword.

On 5 Harh 1663 Bk Guru Sahib Ji laid the foundation of **Sri Akal Takht Sahib**, the throne of the Timeless One, facing Sri Harmandir Sahib. Only three pairs of hands built it: Guru Sahib Ji's, Baba Buddha Ji's and Bhai Gurdas Ji's. Guru Sahib Ji told the sangat that from that day they would bow to the true throne of Akal and to no false worldly throne.

ਸਾਖੀ ੧ — ਗਵਾਲੀਅਰ ਕਿਉਂ? · Why Gwalior (ਜਾਰੀ · continued)



Sri Guru Hargobind Sahib Ji on the original Akal Bunga. Naqqash mural, Gurdwara Baba Atal Rai, 19th century, public domain.

Your turban, or Jahangir's? The dhadis Abdul and Nath Mal sang in the darbar:

ਦੋ ਤਲਵਾਰੀ ਬੱਧੀਆਂ, ਇਕ ਮੀਰੀ ਦੀ ਇਕ ਪੀਰੀ ਦੀ ।
ਇਕ ਅਜਮਤ ਦੀ, ਇਕ ਰਾਜ ਦੀ, ਇਕ ਰਾਖੀ ਕਰੇ ਵਜੀਰ ਦੀ ।
…
ਪੱਗ ਤੇਰੀ, ਕੀ ਜਹਾਂਗੀਰ ਦੀ ।

(Transcribed from our teaching deck. This is a dhadi vaar, not Gurbani.)

The sangat brought horses and weapons as offerings, and 52 young men became Guru Sahib Ji's guard. A court that had just taken the life of Sri Guru Arjan Dev Ji now watched Sri Guru Hargobind Sahib Ji wear a sword. *Vichar:* the vaar asks whose turban truly carries honour. A turban bought with power, or one the sangat crowns with love?

ਸਾਖੀ ੨ — ਕਿਲ੍ਹੇ ਵਿੱਚ · In the fort



Baba Buddha Ji, fresco at Gurdwara Baba Bir Singh, 19th century, public domain.

Gwalior. On Jahangir's order Guru Sahib Ji were held in Gwalior Fort, a hill fortress for royal prisoners. Many hill rajas were already captive there. The way the sakhi is told, Guru Sahib Ji kept to nitnem, kirtan and bandagi in the fort, and the imprisoned rajas came to sit in that sangat.

What people said, and Bhai Gurdas Ji's answer. Bhai Gurdas Ji, who lived through these years, wrote a pauri that sets out what people were saying about Sri Guru Hargobind Sahib Ji, then answers it:

ਪਾਤਿਸਾਹ ਘਰਿ ਆਵਦੇ ਗੜਿ ਚੜਿਆ ਪਾਤਿਸਾਹ ਚੜਾਇਆ ।
ਸਚੁ ਨ ਲੁਕੈ ਲੁਕਾਇਆ ਚਰਣ ਕਵਲ ਸਿਖ ਭਵਰ ਲੁਭਾਇਆ ।
ਅਸਰੁ ਜਰੈ ਨ ਆਪੁ ਜਣਾਇਆ ।।੨੪।।
— ਭਾਈ ਗੁਰਦਾਸ ਜੀ, ਵਾਰ ੨੬, ਪਉੜੀ ੨੪

Meaning. Emperors used to come to the door of Guru Sahiban, and now an emperor has sent Guru Sahib Ji up into a fort. But truth cannot be hidden by hiding it. Sikhs are drawn to the lotus feet like bees. Guru Sahib Ji bore the unbearable and did not make a show of it.

Vichar. ਅਸਰੁ ਜਰੈ, bearing what cannot be borne, is the mark of the house of Sri Guru Nanak Dev Ji. Guru Sahib Ji answered prison with patience, not with complaint. Where in your own life could you meet hardship with ਸਹਿਣਸ਼ੀਲਤਾ rather than noise?

Baba Buddha Ji's chaunki. The sangat of Amritsar longed for darshan. Baba Buddha Ji, already very old and the one who had placed the tilak on five Guru Sahiban, led them on foot to Gwalior, singing Gurbani all the way. They circled the fort in reverence and turned home. Guru Sahib Ji blessed that chaunki to go on for ever, and each night, around 8 pm, Baba Buddha Ji's chaunki still goes round Sri Harmandir Sahib.

The bee and the lotus. The fort walls were high, but love's road was not closed. A bee finds the lotus by its scent across miles, and the sangat walked roughly 800 km to reach Guru Sahib Ji. The fort held Guru Sahib Ji's body. The sangat's hearts were already bound at their feet.

ਸਾਖੀ ੩ — ਰਿਹਾਈ · The release



Sri Guru Hargobind Sahib Ji leading the 52 rajas out of Gwalior Fort. 19th century, public domain.

The order. The sakhi tells that Sain Mian Mir Ji spoke for Guru Sahib Ji before the emperor. This is the same faqir who had wept at the shaheedi of Sri Guru Arjan Dev Ji. The order for release was carried to Gwalior by **Wazir Khan**, a courtier of Jahangir (not the later Nawab of Sirhind), and Hari Das of the fort brought Guru Sahib Ji the news.

"Not alone." Guru Sahib Ji would not walk out and leave behind the rajas who had shared their sangat in the fort. A condition was set: only as many as could hold Guru Sahib Ji's garment could leave. Guru Sahib Ji had a **chola stitched with 52 ਕਲੀਆਂ**. Each raja took hold of one, and all 52 walked out of Gwalior Fort with Guru Sahib Ji. From that day the sangat has called Guru Sahib Ji **ਦਾਤਾ ਬੰਦੀ ਛੋੜ**, the giver who frees the captives.

ਬੰਧਨ ਕਾਟਿ ਬਿਸਾਰੇ ਅਉਗਨ ਅਪਨਾ ਬਿਰਦੁ ਸਮ੍ਹਾਰਿਆ ॥
ਗੁਰਸਿਖ ਰਾਖੇ ਗੁਰ ਗੋਪਾਲਿ ॥ — ਆਸਾ ਮਹਲਾ ੫, ਅੰਗ ੩੮੨

Meaning. Cutting away the bonds and setting aside our failings, Akal Purakh kept true to Their own way. Guru Ji, the Sustainer of the world, protects the Gursikhs.

Vichar: the ਲੜ. The rajas had no strength of their own, only a tassel held tight. In the language of Gurbani, holding Guru Sahib Ji's ਲੜ (hem) means staying attached to Guru Sahib Ji's teaching. Whoever keeps hold is carried along. Ask: what is my "kali"? Nitnem, sangat, seva? What makes me let go?

ਸਾਖੀ ੪ — ਘਰ ਵਾਪਸੀ · Coming home



Sri Harmandir Sahib at night. Photograph: Marsmux, CC BY-SA 4.0.

Data Bandi Chhor Sahib. Where Guru Sahib Ji were held, **Gurdwara Data Bandi Chhor Sahib** now stands on Gwalior Fort. The place an emperor made a prison, Guru Sahib Ji made a place of release.

The lamps of Amritsar. The sangat lit lamps in joy at Guru Sahib Ji's return to Amritsar. The tradition has kept that night ever since: on Diwali Sri Harmandir Sahib shines with ਦੀਪਮਾਲਾ, and Sikhs keep the day as Bandi Chhor Divas.

ਦੀਵਾ ਮੇਰਾ ਏਕੁ ਨਾਮੁ ਦੁਖੁ ਵਿਚਿ ਪਾਇਆ ਤੇਲੁ ॥
ਉਨਿ ਚਾਨਣਿ ਓਹੁ ਸੋਖਿਆ ਚੂਕਾ ਜਮ ਸਿਉ ਮੇਲੁ ॥੧॥ — ਆਸਾ ਮਹਲਾ ੧, ਅੰਗ ੩੫੮

Meaning. The One Name is my lamp, and into it I have poured the oil of suffering. Its light has dried that oil away, and my meeting with death is over.

ਦੀਵਾਲੀ ਦੀ ਰਾਤਿ ਦੀਵੇ ਬਾਲੀਅਨਿ । ਤਾਰੇ ਜਾਤਿ ਸਨਾਤਿ ਅੰਬਰਿ ਭਾਲੀਅਨਿ ।
... ਗੁਰਮੁਖਿ ਸੁਖ ਫਲ ਦਾਤਿ ਸਬਦਿ ਸਮ੍ਹਾਲੀਅਨਿ ॥੬॥ — ਭਾਈ ਗੁਰਦਾਸ ਜੀ, ਵਾਰ ੧੯, ਪਉੜੀ ੬

Meaning. On the night of Diwali lamps are lit, and stars of every kind fill the sky. Like flowers and pilgrim crowds, they pass. The Gurmukh keeps the lasting gift through the Shabad.

Vichar: two kinds of lamp. Outer lamps go out when the oil runs dry. The lamp of Naam burns suffering itself as its oil, just as Guru Sahib Ji stayed a light in the dark of the fort. Light a diya this Diwali, and ask what lamp is burning inside.

For the class · ਜਮਾਤ ਲਈ

ਸ਼ਬਦ-ਜੋਤ · Words to know ਮੀਰੀ · ਪੀਰੀ · ਨਜ਼ਰਬੰਦ (held under guard) · ਚੌਂਕੀ (a kirtan sitting; here, the procession of kirtan) · ਚੋਲਾ · ਕਲੀ (a panel or tassel of the chola) · ਲੜ (hem; to hold Guru Sahib Ji's hem) · ਬੰਦੀ ਛੋੜ (freer of captives) · ਭਾਣਾ (the Will) · ਦੀਪਮਾਲਾ (rows of lamps) · ਅਜਰੁ ਜਰਨਾ (to bear the unbearable)

Questions — younger students (7–11)

1. Why did Guru Sahib Ji wear two swords? What does each one stand for?
2. How did Baba Buddha Ji and the sangat show their love while Guru Sahib Ji were in the fort?
3. How many kalian did the chola have, and why?
4. Why do we light diyas on Bandi Chhor Divas?

Questions — older students and adults

1. Japji Sahib says ਬੰਦਿ ਖਲਾਸੀ ਭਾਣੈ ਹੋਇ. How does the Gwalior sakhi show that release lies in the Will, not with the emperor?
2. Bhai Gurdas Ji says ਸਚੁ ਨ ਲੁਕੈ ਲੁਕਾਇਆ. When have you seen truth come out however hard it was hidden?
3. Guru Sahib Ji refused freedom for themselves alone. Who in our sangat today is "left in the fort", and what would holding out a kali to them look like?
4. Compare the lamp of Ang 358 with the lamps of Vaar 19. Which lasts, and why?

A practice for the week: read Japji Sahib's 25th pauri each morning, and each evening name one person you helped "walk out" of a difficulty.

Where the sources differ. We give the Bikrami dates from Gurbani Paath Darpan. The year and length of the detention are not settled. One source places Guru Sahib Ji's meeting with the Sikhs at Batala on Phagun sangrand 1676 Bk rather than at Diwali. The names of Wazir Khan and Hari Das, and Sain Mian Mir Ji's part, come from tradition as recorded on SikhiWiki.

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